

Body, Coherence, and Hume's Galley

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ABSTRACT Section 1.4.2 of Hume's *Treatise* offers both a constancy-based and a coherence-based explanation of the belief in body. Why two explanations of the belief rather than one? Hume says that the mechanism of the coherence-based explanation is "too weak" to support "so vast an edifice" as the belief in body. I argue that this claim stems from his holding that the belief in body is irresistible, such that its denial can be sustained "in words only." The constancy-based explanation is required in order to explain that property of the belief. This interpretation sheds light on Hume's engagement with Pyrrhonian skepticism.

KEYWORDS Hume, body, coherence, skepticism, belief

SECTION 1.4.2 OF THE *TREATISE*, "Of scepticism with regard to the senses," answers the question: what causes belief in the continued and distinct existence of body? After establishing that the imagination, rather than the senses or reason, is responsible for the belief in body, the section anatomizes two processes of that faculty by which the belief is produced. According to the coherence-based explanation, the belief is produced in response to sensory impressions that exhibit the property of coherence, or "regular dependence on each other" (*T* 1.4.2.19).¹ According to the constancy-based explanation, it is produced in response to sensory impressions that exhibit constancy, or "present themselves in the same uniform manner" (*T* 1.4.2.18). Why does Hume provide two explanations of the belief in body rather than one?² The passage most relevant to this question is among the section's most cryptic. After presenting the coherence-based explanation, Hume effects what Winkler calls a "puzzling shift" to the constancy-based explanation: "But whatever force we may ascribe to this principle, I am afraid 'tis too weak to support alone so vast an edifice, as is that of the continu'd existence of all external bodies; and that

¹Citations of Hume's *Treatise* give the book, part, section, and paragraph number in the Clarendon edition. All emphasis is original unless otherwise noted.

²An early discussion of this problem is found in Laird, *Hume's Philosophy*, 149.

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we must join the constancy of their appearance to the coherence, in order to give a satisfactory account of that opinion" (*T* 1.4.2.23).³ I call this the *transition passage*.⁴

Commentators have offered a variety of proposals as to the deficiency of the principle invoked by the coherence-based explanation.⁵ Some endorse what Loeb calls the *dissatisfaction hypothesis*, according to which Hume regards the coherence-based explanation as inadequate, such that it is not included in his considered identification of the causes of the belief in body.⁶ The hypothesis is highly significant for our understanding of Hume's discussion of skepticism regarding sensory belief. It would imply a simple explanation of his providing the constancy-based explanation in addition to the coherence-based explanation: a second explanation is required due to the failure of the first. Further, the hypothesis has implications for the grounds of Hume's negative epistemic evaluation of the belief in body. *T* 1.4.2 undermines the epistemic merit of the belief by appeal to aspects of its etiology. If the coherence-based explanation is not included in Hume's considered account of the belief, then *T* 1.4.2's skeptical conclusion derives solely from considerations regarding the mechanisms of the constancy-based explanation.⁷

I offer a new account of the transition passage's claim that the psychological mechanism of the coherence-based explanation is "too weak." My thesis is that the claim stems from Hume's holding that the belief in body is psychologically irresistible; its denial can be sustained "in words only" (*T* 1.4.2.50).⁸ The

³Winkler, "Hume on Skepticism," 152. Bennett (*Locke, Berkeley, Hume*, 329) refers to the passage as a "blatantly unguarded assertion" that is "abrupt" and "dogmatic."

⁴Another important passage occurs at *T* 1.4.2.19, where Hume claims that the constancy of sensory impressions is "not so perfect as not to admit of very considerable exceptions." An explanation of the belief in body according to which it is produced in response to constant impressions would not account for all instances of the belief. This might suggest that the "weakness" of the coherence-based explanation stems from its being unable to account for all instances of the belief. I discuss this reading in section 2. That not all impressions that occasion belief in body exhibit constancy is compatible with an explanation of the belief according to which all instances of it are produced in response to coherent impressions, if all cases of constancy are also cases of coherence.

⁵Bennett maintains that the transition passage is partly explained by the fact that "Hume does have an alternative account of how we come by The Belief, and he is determined to work it in somehow" (*Locke, Berkeley, Hume*, 329). Similarly, Noonan writes: "It is possible that Hume simply had an alternative account to offer, one that appeals to constancy, and found it more convincing" (*Hume on Knowledge*, 176). Wright suggests that the deficiency of the mechanism of the coherence-based explanation is that it may not generate "the robust judgment of continued unperceived independent existence which Hume sought" (*Hume's "A Treatise,"* 145). Allison holds that the mechanism of the coherence-based explanation is too weak because the belief in body "rests on the constancy as well as the coherence of impressions" (*Custom and Reason*, 238). Garrett says that coherence plays a secondary role in Hume's account, in part because "the very regularities in question are much more easily discerned once the mind is already thinking of a world of continued and distinct bodies" (*Hume*, 100). Costelloe says that "Hume is silent on the reasons why coherence alone is inadequate" (*Imagination in Hume's Philosophy*, 78). I discuss below proposals due to Ainslie, *Hume's True Scepticism*; Baxter, "External World"; and Loeb, *Stability and Justification*.

⁶Loeb, *Stability and Justification*, 187. Loeb does not himself accept the hypothesis.

⁷This need not be understood as a mark against the hypothesis. There is evidence that the constancy-based explanation is at least chiefly responsible for Hume's skeptical verdict. The justification of that conclusion occurs in *T* 1.4.2.56, where Hume writes that constancy "has the most considerable effect, and yet is attended with the greatest difficulties."

⁸Hume's holding that some beliefs are resistible is compatible with his doxastic involuntarism, according to which the mind cannot "believe whatever it pleases" (*EU* 5.10). See Qu, "Hume's Doxastic Involuntarism," 54–59, for evidence that Hume accepts doxastic involuntarism.

coherence-based explanation essentially invokes a propensity of the imagination that commentators have called “the galley,” the imagination’s tendency to continue on the same course “even when its object fails it” (*T* 1.4.2.22). This is a resistible psychological propensity. An explanation of the belief in body that appeals to it cannot explain the irresistibility of the belief. While Hume does not wholly reject the coherence-based explanation, he does regard it as insufficient to account for the inevitability of the commitment to an external world.

I begin with an overview of Hume’s accounts of the belief in body (section 1). I then argue that Hume’s providing two accounts of the belief rather than one is explained by his commitment to its psychological irresistibility (section 2). I conclude with discussion of the way in which this proposal illuminates Hume’s engagement with the doxastic prescriptions that are, on his reading, constitutive of Pyrrhonian skepticism (section 3).

I. CONSTANCY AND COHERENCE

I begin with an overview of *T* 1.4.2. An object is a body just in case it exhibits *continued* and *distinct* existence.⁹ The question “What causes induce us to believe in the existence of body?” reduces to two others: Why do we believe that objects exhibit continued existence? And why do we believe that objects exhibit distinct existence? An object exhibits continued existence just in case it continues to exist when it is “not present to the senses” (*T* 1.4.2.2). An object exhibits distinct existence just in case it exhibits *external* and *independent existence*. What it is for an object to have external existence is for it to have spatial location outside of the mind. And what it is for an object to have independent existence is for it to exist and operate independently of its being perceived (*T* 1.4.2.2).

Hume claims that an object exhibits continued existence just in case it exhibits distinct existence. One component of this biconditional is dubious: distinct existence does not seem to entail continued existence.¹⁰ An object might cease to exist whenever it is unperceived even if it does not depend for its existence on its being perceived.¹¹ This objection is not significant by Hume’s lights, because it is the truth of the other direction of the biconditional—that continued existence entails distinct existence—that is required by *T* 1.4.2. In both explanations of the belief in body, Hume’s initial explanandum is the belief that an object enjoys continued existence. Belief in an object’s continued existence “without much study or reflection draws the other along with it” (*T* 1.4.2.44). Because continued existence entails distinct existence, the mind is naturally led from belief in the former to belief in the latter. The claim that distinct existence entails continued existence is idle in *T* 1.4.2’s explanatory framework.

There are two versions of the belief in body: the *vulgar* and the *philosophical*. These differ with regard to the objects to which they attribute continued and distinct existence. The vulgar do not distinguish between sensory impressions and

⁹See Boehm, “Concept of Body,” for discussion of Hume’s philosophy of body.

¹⁰See Allison, *Custom and Reason*, 231; Fogelin, *Hume’s Skeptical Crisis*, 59; Noonan, *Hume on Knowledge*, 163; Price, *Hume’s Theory*, 18; and Stroud, *Hume*, 259n2.

¹¹Dicker (“Three Questions,” 116–24) defends Hume’s claim that distinct existence entails continued existence. See Ainslie, *Hume’s True Scepticism*, 48n10, for discussion.

the objects by which sensory impressions are caused. Because “this is a distinction, which is not comprehended by the generality of mankind,” “those very sensations, which enter by the eye or ear, are with them the true objects” (*T* 1.4.2.31). The items to which the vulgar attribute continued and distinct existence are sensory impressions. Because the vulgar do not distinguish between bodies and sensory impressions and, accordingly, lack the concept <sensory impression>, the vulgar belief is *de re* rather than *de dicto*: the vulgar believe, of sensory impressions, that these enjoy continued and distinct existence. The philosophical version of the belief requires a distinction between bodies and impressions: philosophers attribute continued and distinct existence to objects that are supposed to be numerically and specifically distinct from impressions. The initial explanandum of both the coherence-based explanation and constancy-based explanation is the vulgar belief.¹² I use ‘belief in body’ to refer to the vulgar belief.

The belief in body is a product of the imagination’s reaction to two properties exhibited by sensory impressions. Some impressions exhibit *constancy*: “These mountains, and houses, and trees, which lie at present under my eye, have always appear’d to me in the same order; and when I lose sight of them by shutting my eyes or turning my head, I soon after find them return upon me without the least alteration” (*T* 1.4.2.18). Impressions that exhibit constancy exhibit qualitative identity (“invariableness”) (*T* 1.4.2.30). One has an impression of a mountain at t_1 . At t_2 , one looks away from the mountain before, at t_3 , turning back to the mountain to find it as it was. One’s impression at t_1 is qualitatively identical to one’s impression at t_3 , despite the temporal gap between them. These impressions exhibit constancy: they “present themselves in the same uniform manner, and change not upon account of any interruption in my seeing or perceiving them” (*T* 1.4.2.18). A series of impressions that exhibit constancy exhibits what Price calls “gap-indifference,” preserving qualitative identity irrespective of temporal gaps.¹³

Some impressions exhibit *coherence*: “Bodies often change their position and qualities, and after a little absence or interruption may become hardly knowable. But here ’tis observable, that even in these changes they preserve a *coherence*, and have a regular dependence on each other” (*T* 1.4.2.19). Impressions in a series exhibit coherence just in case the series instantiates a regularity irrespective of temporal gaps.¹⁴ “When I return to my chamber after an hour’s absence, I find not

¹²The distinction between the vulgar and philosophical belief in body is drawn only in the course of Hume’s constancy-based explanation (*T* 1.4.2.31, 1.4.2.46). Hume is not explicit as to which version of the belief is the explanandum of the coherence-based explanation. But he does imply that the belief explained by the imagination’s reaction to coherence is a result of our “infer[ring] the continu’d existence of the *objects of sense*” (*T* 1.4.2.21, emphasis added). The same paragraph repeats a finding of section 1.2.6: that “nothing is ever really present to the mind, besides its own perceptions” (*T* 1.4.2.21, 1.2.6.8). The “objects of sense” to which one attributes continued and distinct existence by virtue of coherence are impressions.

¹³Price, *Hume’s Theory*, 60.

¹⁴Kemp Smith says that coherence, unlike constancy, “concerns perceptions in their *absence* rather than in their presence” (*Philosophy of David Hume*, 473, emphasis original). But coherence, like constancy, is a property exhibited by impressions as they appear through temporal gaps. Black (“Coherence and Constancy,” 5) argues that whereas coherence is a relation that obtains between sets of impressions, constancy is a relation that obtains between individual impressions in a series. But see *T* 1.4.2.22, in which Hume claims that “objects have a certain coherence even as they appear to our

my fire in the same situation, in which I left it: But then I am accustom'd in other instances to see a like alteration produc'd in a like time, whether I am present or absent, near or remote" (T 1.4.2.19). Whenever one has had an impression of embers, this impression has appeared after an impression of a fire. One has an impression of a fire at t_1 before leaving the room at t_2 . At t_3 , one returns to find embers where the fire was previously. This series instantiates the regularity of embers' appearing after fires irrespective of the temporal gap between one's impression at t_1 and one's impression at t_3 .

The psychological mechanism invoked by the coherence-based explanation resembles that which underlies causal reasoning: coherence is the "foundation of a kind of reasoning from causation" (T 1.4.2.19). Both involve *custom*: the propensity of the imagination by virtue of which "the repetition of any particular act or operation produces a propensity to renew the same act or operation" (EU 5.5).¹⁵ On numerous occasions, one has observed embers to be immediately preceded by dwindling fires. By virtue of custom, whenever one has an impression of embers, one believes that there existed a dwindling fire. At t_1 , one observes a roaring fire before leaving the room at t_2 . At t_3 , one returns to find embers where one observed the roaring fire. One has observed embers but not a dwindling fire. This case is an "objection" to a "maxim" one has formed "concerning the connexions between causes and effects": that embers are always immediately preceded by dwindling fires. The present case is "contrary" to previous experience unless one supposes that the fire continued to exist during one's absence at t_2 . "In order to preserve the same dependance and connexion, of which [one has] had experience," one must suppose that the fire "existed and operated" when it was unperceived (T 1.4.2.20). Coherence cases such as this *prima facie* have the same structure as ordinary causal reasoning, in which one infers the existence of x upon the observation of y because one is accustomed to observing y in conjunction with x . But Hume denies that custom is individually sufficient to explain the coherence-based belief in body: it arises from custom in a merely "indirect and oblique manner" (T 1.4.2.21).

Compare two inferences: (i) Half of all A s have been B s; I therefore expect it to be as likely as not that the next A will be a B . (ii) Half of all A s have been B s; I therefore expect it to be more likely than not that the next A will be a B .¹⁶ Inferences produced solely by custom resemble (i). Custom leads us to expect that an event will occur with the same frequency as it had in the past. Coherence-based inference to the belief in continued existence resembles (ii). Hume says that "whenever we infer the continu'd existence of the objects of sense from their coherence, and the frequency of their union, 'tis in order to bestow on the objects a greater regularity than what is observ'd in our mere perceptions" (T 1.4.2.21). When one observes

senses." Hume's claim is that impressions are observed to cohere *with one another*. I intend my discussion to be neutral on the issue of whether all series that exhibit constancy also exhibit coherence. Price (*Hume's Theory*, 60) suggests that constancy is just monotonous coherence. See Loeb, *Stability and Justification*, 178–79, for discussion.

¹⁵Citations of the first *Enquiry* give the section and paragraph numbers from the Clarendon edition.

¹⁶I borrow this example from Winkler, "Hume on Skepticism," 153. For a more skeptical view of this claim, see Bennett, *Learning*, 296. Hume's own account of the probability of causes is at least chiefly concerned with explaining not, for example, *full belief* in "Half of the future A s will be B s" but rather *partial assent* to "The future A s will be B s."

a roaring fire at t_1 , leaves at t_2 , and returns at t_3 to find embers, one infers that a dwindling fire existed at t_2 . This is one of many cases in which one's observation of embers was not preceded by observation of a dwindling fire. Were one's belief in the continued existence of the fire a product of custom alone, one's commitment to the existence of a dwindling fire at t_2 would be proportional to the regularity with which one's observations of embers have been preceded by observations of dwindling fires and, accordingly, one would believe that it is merely likely that a dwindling fire existed during one's absence at t_2 . But one's belief in the existence of the fire at t_2 is not incomplete in this way. Coherence-based inferences that produce belief in continued existence cannot be products of unaided habit.

Because custom alone is insufficient to explain the coherence-based belief in continued existence, Hume appeals to another propensity of the imagination: "I have already observ'd,* in examining the foundation of mathematics, that the imagination, when set into any train of thinking, is apt to continue, even when its object fails it, and like a galley put in motion by the oars, carries on its course without any new impulse" (*T* 1.4.2.22).¹⁷ I call this propensity *the galley*.¹⁸ This is the imagination's propensity to continue on the same course "even when its object fails it" (*T* 1.4.2.22). Price calls it the "inertia of the imagination."¹⁹ Generally, the galley is the imagination's propensity to continue on with what it is already doing, even once the initial reason for the operation no longer obtains. In some cases, the galley disposes one to attribute to an object a greater degree of a property that one has already observed the object to exhibit to some degree. One way the imagination achieves this is by attributing an *additional* property or relation to the object.

The galley cooperates with custom to produce the coherence-based belief in body:

The same principle makes us easily entertain this opinion of the continu'd existence of body. Objects have a certain coherence even as they appear to our senses; but this coherence is much greater and more uniform, if we suppose the objects to have a continu'd existence; and as the mind is once in the train of observing an uniformity among objects, it naturally continues, till it renders the uniformity as compleat as possible. The simple supposition of their continu'd existence suffices for this purpose, and gives us a notion of a much greater regularity among objects, than what they have when we look no farther than our senses. (*T* 1.4.2.22)

The objects of coherence cases are observed to exhibit some degree of regularity. One observes embers to be frequently preceded by dwindling fires, and one observes dwindling fires to be frequently preceded by roaring fires. When one observes a roaring fire at t_1 , leaves at t_2 , and returns at t_3 to find smoldering embers, the objects in this sequence exhibit a degree of coherence. In this case, one's observations accord with the regularity that embers are preceded by roaring fires. Having observed this coherence, the imagination is disposed to attribute to the objects an even greater degree of coherence "till it renders the uniformity as

¹⁷The "*" marks a footnote to *T* 1.2.4.

¹⁸See Ehli, "Modal Projection," 171; Loeb, *Stability and Justification*, 186; and Price, *Hume's Theory*, 54–55.

¹⁹Price, *Hume's Theory*, 54.

compleat as possible" (*T* 1.4.2.22). Hume holds that the imagination increases the coherence of the objects by means of the "simple supposition of their continu'd existence" (*T* 1.4.2.22). By virtue of the galley, the imagination attributes to the fire an additional property—continued existence—as a means of attributing a greater degree of coherence. The galley secures one's commitment to the conclusion that the fire continues to exist during one's absence at t_2 .

The constancy-based explanation appeals to the *identity-ascribing propensity*: the imagination's propensity to ascribe identity to related objects. Hume argues that the "principle of individuation is nothing but the *invariableness* and *uninterruptedness* of any object, thro' a suppos'd variation of time" (*T* 1.4.2.30). Objects that exhibit constancy are dissimilar from objects that exhibit identity insofar as the latter but not the former enjoy uninterrupted existence. But objects that exhibit constancy and objects that exhibit identity nonetheless place "the mind in the same disposition, when it considers them" (*T* 1.4.2.34). The mind is thereby disposed to mistake the idea of a constant object for that of an identical object and to predicate identity of the former. Next, the mind notices that the constant object to which one has attributed identity has an "interrupted manner of . . . appearance," which, because identity requires uninterrupted existence, appears inconsistent with one's ascription of identity to the object (*T* 1.4.2.36). This tension renders the mind "uneasy" (*T* 1.4.2.37). To alleviate the uneasiness, one removes the tension between one's ascription of identity and observation of interruptedness by supposing that the object continues to exist between one's observations of it and, hence, enjoys uninterrupted as well as invariable existence. Hume concludes the constancy-based explanation with an account of how this supposition comes to be believed, to which I return in section 2.

2. IRRESISTIBLE BELIEF

What explains Hume's negative assessment of the coherence-based explanation?²⁰ Recall the transition passage:

But whatever force we may ascribe to this principle, I am afraid 'tis too weak to support alone so vast an edifice, as is that of the continu'd existence of all external bodies; and that we must join the *constancy* of their appearance to the *coherence*, in order to give a satisfactory account of that opinion. (*T* 1.4.2.23)

The "principle" to which this passage refers is often taken to be either the mechanism invoked by the coherence-based explanation—custom in cooperation with the galley—or coherence itself.²¹ Ainslie argues that Hume is dissatisfied

²⁰I intend my claim that Hume offers a negative assessment of the coherence-based explanation to be neutral regarding the truth of the dissatisfaction hypothesis. A reading may, for example, hold that Hume offers a negative assessment of the coherence-based explanation only insofar as he holds that it cannot explain all instances of the belief in body, even if it is adequate for explaining many instances. Hume's assessment of the coherence-based explanation would be negative only insofar as he holds that it is not a comprehensive account of the belief's causes. This would not imply that the coherence-based explanation is not, as the dissatisfaction hypothesis maintains, included in Hume's considered account of the belief's causes.

²¹For the former reading, see Black, "Coherence and Constancy," 8; Loeb, *Stability and Justification*, 188; and Schmitt, *Hume's Epistemology*, 263. Baxter, "External World," 119; Costelloe, *Imagination in Hume's Philosophy*, 78; Dicker, "Hume on the External World," 261; and Price, *Hume's Theory*, 37, imply

with the coherence-based explanation, because the explanation presupposes Hume's accounts of general ideas and causal inference, which accounts themselves presuppose that there exist objects that enjoy continued and distinct existence.²² For Ainslie, the explanation "starts too late in the game." Loeb argues that, in Hume's view, the mechanism of the coherence-based explanation cannot explain the full scope of the belief in body: custom and galley must be supplemented by the identity-ascribing mechanism, as invoked by the constancy-based explanation, in order to explain all attributions of continued and distinct existence.²³ Baxter suggests that the mechanism of the coherence-based explanation is deficient because "it could at best give us the belief of the continued and distinct existence of types of objects."²⁴ For Baxter, the mechanism is inadequate because it cannot explain the attribution of continued and distinct existence to particulars.

Such proposals may identify genuine shortcomings of the coherence-based explanation. But there is reason to think that they do not capture the source of the transition passage's claim that "this principle" is too weak to explain the belief in body. Two uses of 'principle' occur in the passage's immediate context. In paragraph 21, Hume explains why the mechanism underlying the coherence-based belief in body is "at the bottom considerably different" from that of causal reasoning. The paragraph concludes, "the extending of custom and reasoning beyond the perceptions can never be the direct and natural effect of the constant repetition and connexion, but must arise from the co-operation of some other *principles*" (T 1.4.2.21, emphasis added).²⁵ This is followed by Hume's explaining, in paragraph 22, the galley's contribution to the coherence-based belief in body. Crucially, in that paragraph, he says of the galley, "The same *principle* makes us easily entertain this opinion of the continu'd existence of body" (T 1.4.2.22, emphasis added). His next use of 'principle' is that which occurs in the transition passage. Evidently, the galley is the additional principle to which Hume appeals to complete the coherence-based explanation. When the transition passage refers to "this principle," the intended referent is the galley. Contrary to the proposals in view, the principle of which the transition passage expresses a negative assessment is just one component of the mechanism invoked by the coherence-based explanation: the galley.²⁶

An alternative account of Hume's providing two explanations of the belief in body rather than one is required. I have argued that the transition passage says that the galley, rather than the "co-operation" of that propensity and custom, is

that the "principle" to which Hume refers is coherence itself. Magri, *Hume's Imagination*, 314; Noonan, *Hume on Knowledge*, 176; Winkler, "Hume on Skepticism," 153; and Wright, *Hume's "A Treatise,"* 144, hold that the principle is the galley.

²²Ainslie, *Hume's True Scepticism*, 73–74.

²³Loeb, *Stability and Justification*, 191. See also Black, "Coherence and Constancy," 8; and Schmitt, *Hume's Epistemology*, 263.

²⁴Baxter, "External World," 119.

²⁵I take Hume to use the plural 'principles' to refer to the galley and the propensities of the imagination that will be invoked by the constancy-based explanation.

²⁶This feature of the text undermines another possible source of Hume's negative assessment: his recognizing that the coherence-based explanation cannot, unlike the constancy-based explanation, adequately explain how the supposition of continued existence becomes *lively* and, hence, *believed*. This would be a defect of the coherence-based explanation as a whole, not of the galley in particular.

“too weak” to explain the belief in body. What is the meaning of ‘weak,’ as used in the passage? A passage from *T* 1.4.4, “Of the modern philosophy,” suggests a possible answer. *T* 1.4.4 begins with Hume’s considering an objection to his discussion of the fictions of the ancient philosophy in *T* 1.4.3, “Of the antient philosophy.” Hume had criticized ancient philosophers for their having followed the “suggestions of their fancy.” The objection: “But here it may be objected, that the imagination, according to my own confession, being the ultimate judge of all systems of philosophy, I am unjust in blaming the antient philosophers for . . . allowing themselves to be entirely guided by it” (*T* 1.4.4.1). Hume’s reply:

In order to justify myself, I must distinguish in the imagination betwixt the principles which are *permanent, irresistible, and universal*; such as the customary transition from causes to effects, and from effects to causes: And the principles, which are *changeable, weak, and irregular*; such as those I have just now taken notice of. (*T* 1.4.4.1, emphasis added)

Some propensities are “permanent, irresistible, and universal.” Others are “changeable, weak, and irregular.” The properties ascribed to propensities of the first kind are each the contrary of a property ascribed to propensities of the second kind. Whereas propensities of the first kind are “permanent,” propensities of the second kind are “changeable.”²⁷ Whereas propensities of the first kind are “universal,” propensities of the second kind are “irregular.” This passage uses ‘weak’ as the contrary of ‘irresistible.’ In the taxonomy of propensities of the imagination offered in 1.4.4, Hume uses ‘weak’ to mean *resistible*. My proposal is that the transition passage uses ‘weak’ in this sense and, hence, that the claim that the galley is “too weak” concerns the resistibility of the propensity.²⁸

There is a distinction between two senses in which a propensity may be irresistible. A propensity exhibits *complete irresistibility* just in case it is not psychologically possible for a thinker to suspend an operation of the propensity. A propensity exhibits *incomplete irresistibility* just in case while an operation of the propensity can be suspended, this cannot be sustained indefinitely. If a propensity is completely irresistible, then suspension is not possible. If a propensity is incompletely irresistible, then suspension is not sustainable. I call a propensity resistible just in case it is neither completely nor incompletely irresistible. There is an analogous distinction with respect to belief: a belief exhibits complete irresistibility just in case it is not psychologically possible for a thinker to suspend that belief for any length of time; a belief exhibits incomplete irresistibility just in case suspension of the belief is psychologically possible but cannot be sustained indefinitely. I call a belief resistible just in case it is neither completely nor incompletely irresistible.²⁹

²⁷Ainslie (*Hume’s True Scepticism*, 74n5) and Cottrell (“Puzzle about Fictions,” 49) take Hume’s ‘changeable’ to mean “changing.” See Baxter, “Hume on Identity,” 331–33, for discussion of Hume’s use of ‘changeable.’

²⁸Sasser seems committed to denying that the galley is resistible, because he holds that “the vulgar belief . . . is produced by permanent, irresistible, and universal propensities” (*Demands of Philosophy*, 89–92). The textual considerations presented in this paragraph do not establish that the “weak” in the transition passage must be understood to be synonymous with ‘resistible.’ They establish that this is one plausible reading of “weak.”

²⁹If a belief is incompletely irresistible, in my sense, then it can be suspended temporarily. But this fact does not imply that the belief is resistible, in my sense. Likewise, if a propensity is incompletely

There is evidence for Hume's holding that the galley is a resistible propensity of the imagination. His presentation of the coherence-based explanation includes a reference to an earlier appeal to the galley in 1.2.4's discussion of geometry. There, he argues that we have no "exact and determinate" standard of equality (*T* 1.2.4.29). The galley is invoked to explain the fiction of a *perfect* standard of equality. Geometers attempt to correct the standards of measurement that they employ, which corrections can be made only in reference to the appearances of objects. As nothing is "more usual, than for the mind to proceed after this manner with any action, even after the reason has ceas'd, which first determin'd it to begin," these corrections lead the mind to continue correcting and to suppose a fictitious, perfectly corrected standard of measurement (*T* 1.2.4.24). By virtue of an analogous operation of the galley, the mechanic is led to suppose that "*swift* and *slow*" are "capable of an exact comparison and equality" (*T* 1.2.4.24). Hume does say that this operation of the galley is very "usual" and that the fictions produced by it are "natural" (*T* 1.2.4.24). But one passage suggests that the propensity is resistible: "Our appeal is still to the weak and fallible judgment, which we make from the appearance of the objects, and correct by a compass or common measure; and *if* we join the supposition of any farther correction, 'tis of such-a-one as is either useless or imaginary" (*T* 1.2.4.29, emphasis added). Here, the supposition produced by the galley is portrayed as optional. Hume's own account of geometry, which makes no use of a supposed perfect standard of equality, provides an example of a thinker's resisting this operation of the propensity.

There are other operations of the galley that Hume regards as resistible. These are brought into view by consideration of the galley's relation to another propensity of the imagination: the *union propensity*. Hume describes the latter propensity as follows: "When objects are united by any relation, we have a strong propensity to add some new relation to them, in order to compleat the union" (*T* 1.4.5.12). The union propensity is the galley applied to the property of unity.³⁰ When one observes objects to be united to some degree due to those objects' being related in some respect to one another, the mind, by virtue of the galley, is disposed to "carr[y] on its course" by attributing to those objects an even greater degree of unity (*T* 1.4.2.22).³¹ The *Treatise* invokes the union propensity frequently. It is used to explain the philosophical commitment to the resemblance of perceptions and the objects that cause them: the imagination attributes the relation of resemblance to sensory impressions and the objects that cause them in order to "compleat the union" it observes between them (*T* 1.4.2.55). The union propensity is also proposed as an explanation for the rule of property "that every one continue to enjoy what he is at present possess'd of" (*T* 3.2.3.4). By virtue of the union

irresistible, then its operation can be suspended temporarily. This does not imply that the propensity is resistible, in my sense.

³⁰See Ehli, "Modal Projection," 171–72. Cottrell calls the union propensity "basic" ("David Hume: Imagination"). Magri lists the galley and union propensity as distinct propensities (*Hume's Imagination*, 472–73).

³¹In *T* 1.2.4 and *T* 1.4.2, the galley is applied to cases involving items that are not experienced: a perfect standard of equality and continued existence. Hume gives no indication that this feature of these operations of the galley is present in *all* its operations. It is compatible with the union propensity's being an instance of the galley that the former is applied to items that are available to experience.

propensity, when someone is observed to stand in the relation of *present* possession to an object, the imagination is disposed to take that person and the object to stand in the relation of *constant* possession, and “property is nothing but a constant possession” (T 3.2.3.4n).³²

At least some operations of the union propensity are resistible. In T 1.4.5, “Of the immateriality of the soul,” Hume uses the propensity to explain ascriptions of spatial location to nonspatial perceptions: smells, tastes, and sounds. Because the taste of a fig is observed to be both caused by and temporally contiguous with the fig, the imagination attributes the additional relation of spatial contiguity to the fig and its taste: “From the relations of causation and contiguity in time betwixt two objects, we feign likewise that of a conjunction in place, in order to strengthen the connexion” (T 1.4.5.12). Hume implies that this commitment is not compulsory, “if ever reason be of sufficient force to overcome prejudice, ’tis certain, that in the present case it must prevail” (T 1.4.5.14). The operation of reason can prevent one’s being led by the union propensity to attribute spatial location to nonspatial perceptions. Additionally, T 1.3.14, “Of the idea of necessary connexion,” implies that the union propensity is the reason why “the mind has a great propensity to spread itself on external objects, and to conjoin with them any internal impressions, which they occasion” (T 1.3.14.25). For example, the propensity explains one’s supposing that necessity is located not in the mind but in external, causally related objects (T 1.3.14.25). Hume holds that one can resist one’s propensity to join one’s perceptions with the objects that cause them: “This inclination, ’tis true, is suppress’d by a little reflection” (T 1.4.3.11). The operation of the union propensity by virtue of which the mind “spreads itself” onto objects is resistible. Because the union propensity just is the galley applied to the property of unity, these applications of the former propensity are also applications of the latter. They are additional cases in which the galley is resistible.

My proposal is that Hume’s complaint in the transition passage is that one component of the psychological mechanism invoked by the coherence-based explanation—the galley—is a resistible propensity of the imagination. The resistibility of a propensity has implications for beliefs produced by it. If the operation of a propensity causes a belief, then the belief would not occur, were the operation suppressed.³³ Because the operation of a resistible propensity can

³²This relation of the union propensity to the galley undermines a common criticism of the coherence-based explanation’s appeal to the latter. Wright says that “the principle of the imagination which Hume postulates as operating in conjunction with the coherence of impressions seems particularly *ad hoc*” (*Sceptical Realism*, 64). MacNabb says that the coherence-based explanation’s appeal to the galley is “rather lame” (*David Hume*, 127). The union propensity is just the galley applied to the property of unity, and we have seen that appeals to the former propensity are numerous in the *Treatise*. Cf. Wright, Hume’s “*A Treatise*,” 145, who says that the galley “does not play any role in other major topics of the *Treatise*” aside from its invocations in T 1.4.2 and 1.2.4. Because the *Treatise* invokes the galley frequently, the coherence-based explanation’s appeal to the propensity is not *ad hoc*.

³³In the first *Enquiry*, Hume claims that if an object is a cause of another, then “if the first object had not been, the second never had existed” (EU 7.29, emphasis removed). In the *Treatise*’s seventh rule for causal judgement, he writes: “The absence or presence of one part of the cause is here suppos’d to be always attended with the absence or presence of a proportionable part of the effect” (T 1.3.15.9; see also T 1.3.12.16). The dependence of an effect on its total cause would imply the dependence of the effect on any one of its partial causes, if the total cause depends for its existence on each of the partial causes.

be suppressed, a belief's having a resistible propensity as a cause renders the belief resistible. Because the cooperation of the galley with custom is, according to the coherence-based explanation, the cause of the belief in body, and because the galley is resistible, the belief in body, as produced in response to cases of coherence, is resistible.³⁴ I suggest that Hume finds this implication of the coherence-based explanation intolerable, because he holds that the belief in body is a paradigm case of belief that is (incompletely) irresistible.

The first paragraph of *T* 1.4.2 tells us that even the skeptic "must assent to the principle concerning the existence of body, tho' he cannot pretend by any arguments of philosophy to maintain its veracity" (*T* 1.4.2.1). Further, Hume claims that it is "in vain to ask, *Whether there be body or not?* That is a point, which we must take for granted in all our reasonings" (*T* 1.4.2.1). And he says that rejection of "the opinion of a continu'd existence" can be maintained "in words only" (*T* 1.4.2.50). These passages imply that belief in body is, in some sense, irresistible. This view is also present in the first *Enquiry*, where Hume claims that Berkeley's arguments "admit of no answer and produce no conviction" (*EU* 12.15n, emphasis removed). Berkeley's arguments produce no conviction not because they are unsound but because they are overwhelmed by one's propensity to believe in body.

We can clarify the sense in which belief in body is irresistible. In asserting the irresistibility of the belief, Hume sometimes writes as if his concern is belief in particular bodies. Other times, he appears concerned with belief in body understood generally: the belief that *some* body exists. For example, in the first *Enquiry*, he says that all animals "preserve this belief of external objects, in all their thoughts, designs, and actions" (*EU* 12.7). The content of the general belief in body is to be understood in terms of Hume's theory of general ideas, according to which ideas that are "particular in their nature" become "general in their representation" (*T* 1.1.7.10). Every meaningful general term is associated with a *revival set*. Revival sets include all and only a thinker's ideas of particulars of the relevant sort. 'Body' is associated with a revival set that includes all and only a thinker's ideas of particular bodies. Use of a general term calls to mind an exemplar idea, which is any member of the term's revival set. The exemplar idea functions as a representation of the relevant sort. Use of 'body' calls to mind an idea of a particular body, which thereby represents the sort 'body.' The general idea of a sort is the idea of a particular of that sort, which idea stands in associative relations with other instances of the sort and is apt to be revived upon the use of the general term associated with the sort (*T* 1.1.7.7). To believe in the existence of body generally is to form a belief the content of which is an idea of a particular body. The general belief that some body exists requires the belief that a particular body exists. If belief in *x* depends for its existence on the existence of belief in *y*, then the resistibility of belief in *y* implies the resistibility of the belief in *x*. Because

³⁴The galley's inclusion in the coherence-based explanation would also seem to render the coherence-based belief epistemically dubious. Whether this is Hume's view depends, in part, on what epistemological theory he endorses in the *Treatise*. See Qu, "Hume's Epistemology," for a survey of recent approaches to Hume's epistemology. The galley is not explicitly mentioned in the skeptical reflections of 1.4.2's penultimate paragraph, although it may be among the "trivial qualities of the fancy" to which Hume refers there (*T* 1.4.2.56).

the general belief in body presupposes the existence of belief in a particular body, the former is irresistible only if beliefs in particular bodies are irresistible. I continue to use 'belief in body' to refer to belief in particular bodies.

We have seen the distinction between the incomplete and complete irresistibility of belief. The philosophical belief in body is neither completely nor incompletely irresistible. In paragraph 51 of *T* 1.4.2, Hume writes, "As long as our attention is bent upon the subject [of body], the philosophical and study'd principle may prevail; but the moment we relax our thoughts, nature will display herself, and draw us back to [the vulgar] opinion" (*T* 1.4.2.51). In paragraph 53, he says that philosophers "immediately upon leaving their closets, mingle with the rest of mankind in those exploded opinions, that our perceptions are our only objects, and continue identically and uninterruptedly the same in all their interrupted appearances" (*T* 1.4.2.53). These passages assert that philosophers may suspend the philosophical belief in favor of the vulgar belief.³⁵ Hume's claim is that they in fact suspend the belief whenever not engaged in philosophical inquiry. Thus, the philosophical belief is not completely irresistible. Further, because suspension of the belief can be maintained so long as one forgoes philosophical inquiry in favor of the activities of common life, the philosophical belief is not incompletely irresistible. These passages also imply that the vulgar belief is incompletely irresistible.³⁶ Because philosophers temporarily suspend the vulgar belief in favor of the philosophical belief, the vulgar belief is not completely irresistible. But, as we have seen, this suspension can be maintained only temporarily.

The vulgar belief in body, unlike the philosophical belief, is incompletely irresistible.³⁷ This property of the vulgar belief explains the transition passage's claim that the galley is "too weak." The coherence-based explanation maintains that the operation of the galley is required for the production of the vulgar belief. The galley is a resistible propensity of the imagination. Because an operation of the galley can be arrested indefinitely, if that propensity is necessary to produce a belief, then indefinite suspension of the belief is psychologically possible. The vulgar belief is the paradigm case of belief indefinite suspension of which is not psychologically possible. Because of its invocation of the galley, the coherence-based explanation is unable to explain the incomplete irresistibility of the vulgar belief. The coherence-based explanation is defective insofar as it fails to explain a characteristic property of the belief in body.³⁸

³⁵Hume rejects the model of belief according to which it is "a simple act of the thought" (*T* 1.4.1.8). Belief depends "not on the will, but must arise from certain determinate causes and principles, of which we are not masters" (*T* App 2). The philosophers' suspension of the vulgar belief should not be understood as the product of an act of will. Instead, it is a decrease in force and vivacity caused by reflection on the vulgar belief. See Baxter, "Hume on Assent"; and Falkenstein, *Consciousness, Time, and Scepticism*, chap. 6, for valuable discussions of the Humean theory of belief.

³⁶Rocknak seems to deny that the vulgar belief is incompletely irresistible, claiming that Hume himself "like everyone else, did entertain the vulgar view at one point in his thought process, although very briefly" ("Vulgar Conception of Objects," 67).

³⁷If a belief is vulnerable to *preemption*, then the belief can be resisted by one's preventing the initial formation of the belief. If a belief is vulnerable to *undermining*, then the belief can be resisted by one's extinguishing the belief after its initial formation. Hume seems to hold both that it is not possible for one to indefinitely prevent the vulgar belief's initial formation and that it is not possible for one to undermine indefinitely the vulgar belief after its initial formation.

³⁸This does not imply that Hume regards the coherence-based explanation as defective in all respects. I discuss two respects in which the explanation is successful in section 3.

This deficiency does not afflict the constancy-based explanation. The chief propensity to which that explanation appeals is the identity-ascribing propensity, which causes one to ascribe identity to invariable but interrupted successions of perceptions. *T* 1.4.2 suggests that this propensity is, in some sense, irresistible. It is said to be a “strong propensity” that is part of the mind’s “first and most natural tendency” (*T* 1.4.2.43, 1.4.2.44). Further, the constancy-based explanation presupposes that the mind is to some extent unable to resist the propensity. The identity-ascribing propensity causes one to ascribe identity to perceptions that exhibit constancy. But one recognizes that the appearance of such perceptions is interrupted, which interruption is in tension with their identity (*T* 1.4.2.37). This tension “gives a sensible uneasiness,” from which the mind seeks relief by “sacrificing the one [commitment] to the other” (*T* 1.4.2.37). Crucially, the mind, rather than abandoning the commitment produced by the identity-ascribing propensity, “*must . . . turn to the other side, and suppose that our perceptions are no longer interrupted,*” which rejection of the interruption of constant perceptions results in one’s feigning their continued existence (*T* 1.4.2.37, emphasis added).

The identity-ascribing propensity is also invoked in *T* 1.4.6, where it is the explanans of ascriptions of identity to the self. The section’s sixth paragraph offers a general account of the propensity’s role in producing the fictions of “soul,” “self,” “substance,” and “the continu’d existence of the perceptions of our senses.” This discussion implies that the propensity is incompletely irresistible. By virtue of the propensity, the mind is apt to ascribe identity to changing successions of objects. Hume says that our propensity to such mistaken ascriptions is “so great from the resemblance above-mention’d, that we fall into it before we are aware; and tho’ we incessantly correct ourselves by reflection, and return to a more accurate method of thinking, yet *we cannot long sustain our philosophy, or take off this bias from the imagination*” (*T* 1.4.6.6, emphasis added). That we “cannot long” suspend the operation of the identity-ascribing propensity implies that it is incompletely irresistible.³⁹ The chief propensity to which the constancy-based explanation appeals is, unlike the galley, an incompletely irresistible propensity of the imagination.

The identity-ascribing propensity explains the mind’s coming to suppose or feign the continued existence of objects that exhibit constancy. Hume concludes

³⁹Noonan holds that the identity-ascribing propensity is irresistible (*Hume on Knowledge*, 130). See also Kemp Smith, “Naturalism of Hume,” 159. Loeb argues that Hume inconsistently treats the propensity as irresistible in the case of body but resistible in the cases of material substance and self (*Stability and Justification*, 173–76). The incomplete irresistibility of the identity-ascribing propensity does not entail that the fiction of material substance and the fiction of self are incompletely irresistible. Each fiction arises from a four-part process, the first stage of which is an operation of the identity-ascribing propensity. In the case of material substance, perception of a succession of sensible qualities leads one to attribute identity to the qualities (*T* 1.4.3.3). In the case of the self, reflection on a succession of perceptions leads one to attribute identity to the perceptions (*T* 1.4.6.6). Even if these ascriptions are incompletely irresistible, the fictions that they induce may nonetheless be resistible, because the relevant processes may operate to produce different, functionally similar fictions. Thus, Hume writes that even “where we do not give rise to such a fiction [i.e. the fictions of ‘soul, self, and substance’], our propension to confound identity with relation is so great, that we are apt to imagine something unknown and mysterious, connecting the parts, beside their relation” (*T* 1.4.6.6). Instead of feigning a self or material substance, we may feign a “mysterious” principle of connection.

the constancy-based explanation with an account of the mechanisms by which the supposition is believed. His account of these mechanisms, coupled with the incomplete irresistibility of the identity-ascribing propensity, secures the incomplete irresistibility of the vulgar belief. The essence of belief is force and vivacity (*T* 1.3.7.5). The supposition of continued existence “acquires a force and vivacity from the memory of these broken impressions, and from that propensity, which they give us, to suppose them the same” (*T* 1.4.2.24). The force and vivacity of the supposition arises from two sources. First, the activation of the identity-ascribing propensity enlivens the supposition that it produces. Thus, Hume says that a “strong propensity or inclination alone . . . will sometimes cause a belief” (*T* 1.4.2.43). Second, the propensity is activated by what are “impressions of the memory” (*T* 1.4.2.42). As a result, it conveys the force and vivacity of those impressions to the supposition of continued existence. With respect to both sources, the transfer of force and vivacity to the supposition goes hand-in-hand with the identity-ascribing propensity’s production of it. If the latter is incompletely irresistible, then so is the former. The constancy-based explanation can explain the incomplete irresistibility of the vulgar belief in body and, hence, does not suffer from the defect that engenders Hume’s negative assessment of the coherence-based explanation.

3. CONCLUSION

Hume’s negative assessment of the coherence-based explanation is a result of its being unable to explain the incomplete irresistibility of the belief in body. This deficiency is a product of the explanation’s appeal to a resistible propensity of the imagination: the galley. We have seen that the transition passage claims that “we must *join* the *constancy* of [the appearance of bodies] to the *coherence*, in order to give a satisfactory account of that opinion” (*T* 1.4.2.23, emphasis added). And *T* 1.4.2’s penultimate paragraph says that “they are the coherence and constancy of our perceptions, which produce the opinion of their continu’d existence,” even if constancy has “the most considerable effect” (*T* 1.4.2.56). According to the present reading, while Hume is dissatisfied with the coherence-based explanation, there are nonetheless two respects in which he regards the explanation as successful. First, the explanation is correct in holding that some instances of belief in body are produced in response to impressions that exhibit coherence. Second, the explanation is correct in holding that custom, as he understands that propensity, is such that it produces belief in continued and distinct existence in response to coherence. But the coherence-based explanation is ultimately inadequate, because it would imply, by virtue of its appeal to the galley, that the belief in body produced in response to coherence is in no sense irresistible. Because the belief in body produced in response to coherence is, like the belief produced in response to constancy, incompletely irresistible, the coherence-based explanation is incomplete. My proposal is that the transition passage acknowledges this explanatory failure. *T* 1.4.2’s second explanation avoids this shortcoming, appealing to a mechanism that secures the incomplete irresistibility of the beliefs that it produces.

This sheds light on the way in which *T* 1.4.2 is shaped by Hume’s engagement with Pyrrhonian skepticism. In Hume’s post-*Treatise* writings, Pyrrhonism is

portrayed as advocating a total suspension of belief.⁴⁰ In the Abstract of the *Treatise*, Hume says that “philosophy would render us entirely *Pyrrhonian*” by forbidding assent to our faculties (*TAbs* 27). In the first *Enquiry*, Pyrrhonism aims to “destroy all assurance and conviction” (*EU* 12.22). And in the *Dialogues*, Pyrrhonians are said to advocate that one “renounce all belief and opinion” (*D* 1.6).⁴¹ In those works, Hume objects to Pyrrhonism on the grounds that adherence to its doxastic prescriptions is psychologically untenable.⁴² We are told that nature is too strong for Pyrrhonian doubt (*TAbs* 27). He claims that “a PYRRHONIAN cannot expect, that his philosophy will have any constant influence on the mind” (*EU* 12.23). And Pyrrhonism, like Stoicism, is faulted for assuming the “erroneous maxim” that “what a man can perform sometimes, and in some dispositions, he can perform always, and in every disposition” (*D* 1.7).⁴³

This response is also present in *T* 1.4.2, where Hume says that while “extravagant sceptics” claim to reject the belief in body, they maintain this rejection “in words only, and were never able to bring themselves sincerely to believe it” (*T* 1.4.2.50). These declarations of the inevitability of the belief in body may strike one as undefended assertion. Hume seems to offer no argument for his psychological objection to the Pyrrhonian recommendation that one suspend sensory belief. Consider also the section’s opening sentences: “Thus the sceptic . . . must assent to the principle concerning the existence of body, tho’ he cannot pretend by any arguments of philosophy to maintain its veracity. Nature has not left this to his choice, and has doubtless esteem’d it an affair of too great importance to be trusted to our uncertain reasonings and speculations” (*T* 1.4.2.1).⁴⁴ By beginning the section with an unguarded pronouncement of the irresistibility of the belief in body, Hume seems to suggest that *T* 1.4.2 will merely assume that the belief has that property. This is mistaken. The incomplete irresistibility of the vulgar belief is not

⁴⁰The accuracy of this interpretation of Pyrrhonism is controversial. See Barnes, “Beliefs of a Pyrrhonist”; Burnyeat, “Can the Sceptic Live His Scepticism?”; Frede, “Two Kinds of Assent”; and Perin, *Demands of Reason*, chap. 3. See Perinetti, “Hume at La Flèche,” for discussion of the skeptical texts available to Hume during the composition of the *Treatise*. Baxter, “Hume on Assent”; Fosl, *Hume’s Scepticism*, chaps. 3–4; and Popkin, “David Hume,” offer important accounts of Hume’s reception of Pyrrhonism.

⁴¹Citations of Hume’s *Dialogues* give the part and paragraph number in the Coleman edition.

⁴²According to Kemp Smith, a central claim of Hume’s epistemology is that certain beliefs are *natural beliefs*: “inevitable” and “indispensable” beliefs that are “removed beyond the reach of our sceptical doubts” (“Naturalism of Hume,” 152). See Loeb, “Kemp Smith Interpretation?”; and Wright, “Two Kinds of Naturalism,” for discussion of the Kemp Smith interpretation.

⁴³That Hume accepts this response to Pyrrhonism in his later writings does not itself establish that he accepts it in the *Treatise*. Qu (*Hume’s Epistemological Evolution*) defends a reading according to which Hume’s epistemological views undergo significant development after the *Treatise*.

⁴⁴A text that might seem to show that the *Treatise* is less sanguine than the later works regarding the psychological impotence of Pyrrhonism is *T* 1.4.2.57, where Hume writes that “sceptical doubt, both with respect to reason and the senses, is a malady, which can never be radically cur’d, but must return upon us every moment, however we may chace it away, and sometimes may seem entirely free from it.” This might be understood to imply that skeptical doubt is incompletely irresistible. Later in the passage, however, Hume writes that “as the sceptical doubt arises naturally from a profound and intense reflection on those subjects, it always encreases, the farther we carry our reflections” (emphasis added). Skeptical doubt is an inevitable conclusion of philosophical reflection on our perceptual and rational capacities, but we are under no psychological compulsion to engage in such reflection. Pyrrhonian suspension can be avoided by refraining from philosophical inquiry. This is the respect in which “carelessness and inattention” provide a remedy to skepticism (*T* 1.4.2.57). I am grateful to an anonymous referee for raising this issue.

presupposed by the section but is a conclusion it aims to establish. Hume provides a second explanation of the belief in body because, by his lights, an explanation that fails to secure the inevitability of the human commitment to an external world cannot be complete. One objective of his investigation of the causal origins of the belief in body is to establish the conclusion that it is “impossible upon any system to defend . . . our senses” (*T* 1.4.2.57). The present interpretation implies that a second, unstated objective is to confirm that Pyrrhonian doubt concerning sensory belief can have no durable hold on our cognitive state but instead inspires mere “momentary amazement and confusion” (*EU* 12.23, emphasis added).⁴⁵

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